

3.2 Maxthon

This browser was created for the IE 5.5 days, when newer browsers with better functionality were appearing on the horizon and Microsoft couldn't care less about updating IE. Even when they finally did, it included functionality that was—by then—almost commonplace in all the alternative browsers. This is when Maxthon was released.

This cannot be called a browser in itself because it borrows the Trident rendering engine used by IE to display Web pages and is more like a GUI upgrade for IE. When it was launched, its tab functionality, password manager, and ability to use IE favourites received quite a positive response from Internet users. Since then, IE 7 incorporates nearly all the features of Maxthon. In spite of this, its fan base remains, albeit diminishing by the day. Maxthon recently released a newer version of their browser, which added more features.

When installing Maxthon 2, you are asked if you want to create an account to store your settings for different users or use one profile for everyone. A few features are not available when using the single profile setup and therefore we choose to create an account. You can choose to automatically login to your account (quite pointless; if you want to share your settings, you'd rather not make that account in the first place!) or enter a password every time you start Maxthon.

Once you are logged in, you can choose to synchronise your bookmarks with an online database. This way you can use any Maxthon browser in the world and log into your account to find all your bookmarks there. Apart from this nifty feature, the browser has an inbuilt Web accelerator called "Super Maxthon Smart Acceleration", which will monitor the Web sites you visit, and cache its images and layout so that they load faster.

Maxthon also has an inbuilt RSS Reader, support for tabs, it can restore the tabs when the browser crashes, has an undo option for when you accidentally close a tab, can block ads, flash, ActiveX and Java applets. It also supports mouse gestures and an automatic update service.

The unique functionality of this browser is in a feature called Groups, which allows you to store bookmarks under a folder. When